Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (HRM1)

Module 6: Strategic HRM and Uganda Public Sector Reform

Lesson 2: Government Reforms and HRM in Uganda

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

Version: 2026

The Uganda Public Service Commission, Legal Basis and Functions

The Uganda Public Service Commission, commonly abbreviated UPSC, is a government agency responsible for overseeing civil service operations. It was established under Article 165 of the 1995 Constitution of the Republic of Uganda, and its operations are further governed by the Public Service Commission Act, Cap. 92, alongside the Public Service Act, Cap. 91, which together set out how hiring, appointment, and advancement of public officials are meant to proceed (Bashaasha, Mangheni, & Nkonya, 2011; Kiiza, 2007).

The Commission's key functions include recruitment and appointment of public employees, disciplinary control over civil servants to uphold ethical standards, oversight of promotion and transfer to support genuine career progression, and management of termination and retirement in line with public service rules. It also establishes standards for hiring and ethical conduct, provides advisory support to the President and other government officials on HR matters, monitors and evaluates the performance of public service organisations, helps develop HR policies for the public sector, resolves appeals from public servants on employment related issues, and works to ensure gender and regional balance in public sector appointments.

Through implementing performance appraisal systems, supporting professional training, and promoting employee welfare, the UPSC has sought to modernise HRM practices within Uganda's public sector over time, in line with the country's broader push toward accountability and good governance (Olowu & Wunsch, 2004; Barkan, Densham, & Njuguna, 2003).

> ***Reflect:*** *Comparing the UPSC's functions to the private sector HR functions covered earlier in this course, which functions look nearly identical, and which are unique to a government context?*

Uganda's Public Service Reforms, 1986 to 2012

Between 1986 and 2012, Uganda undertook significant public service reforms aimed at improving service delivery, accountability, and efficiency, addressing problems including corruption and low civil servant morale (Langseth, 2006; Bashaasha et al., 2011).

Civil service restructuring was among the earliest reforms, reducing the size of an overstaffed public sector workforce. The Civil Service Reform Programme, introduced in 1991, streamlined operations and lowered expenses by removing surplus employees, alongside payroll audits intended to eliminate so called ghost workers, fictitious employees kept on the payroll for fraudulent purposes, and to give remaining public employees more clearly defined roles (Therkildsen, 2000).

Decentralisation, beginning in the early 1990s, transferred administrative and financial authority to local governments, giving districts greater responsibility for services such as water management, education, and health. Under HRM specifically, this meant hiring, training, and supervising employees became a local government responsibility rather than a purely central one. This was intended to bring services closer to the people and strengthen local accountability, though it has also produced uneven service quality, since different districts have very different levels of resources and experience (Muriisa, 2008).

The 1995 Constitution created the legal framework establishing the Public Service Commission itself, prioritising a merit based system for hiring and advancement, alongside a Public Service Code of Conduct meant to encourage professionalism and ethical behaviour. To strengthen anti-corruption efforts, Uganda established the Inspectorate of Government under the Inspectorate of Government Act, Cap. 32, and later reinforced this with the Leadership Code Act, Cap. 33.

Public financial management reforms ran alongside these institutional changes. The Medium Term Expenditure Framework improved budgeting discipline by linking national priorities to resource allocation, while the Integrated Financial Management System strengthened financial reporting and reduced opportunities for waste and fraud. Results Oriented Management was introduced to hold public employees accountable for achieving specific goals, and later, the Public Sector Performance Enhancement Programme introduced performance contracts specifically for senior public officials.

> ***Reflect:*** *Of civil service restructuring, decentralisation, constitutional and institutional reform, and public financial management reform, which do you think has had the most lasting effect on how Uganda's public sector actually manages its people today?*

Public Service Reforms From 2012 to the Present, and Ongoing Challenges

Since 2012, Uganda's public service reform has continued to focus on improving efficiency, effectiveness, and service delivery. Results Oriented Management has continued as a management approach focused on outcomes rather than mere activity. Talent management and recruitment have been strengthened through merit based hiring overseen by the Public Service Commission, alongside digitalised hiring processes such as e-recruitment systems intended to improve speed, transparency, and reduce corruption and nepotism in public sector hiring.

Training and capacity building has continued through institutions such as the Uganda Management Institute, which offers specialised training to strengthen public servants' administrative and service delivery capacity. Wage and compensation reforms have aimed to standardise pay systems and reduce disparities, although government salaries generally remain comparatively low, with performance based incentives still limited in availability and scope.

Anti-corruption efforts remain closely tied to HR reform. HR departments within government coordinate with the Office of the Auditor General and the Inspectorate of Government, established under the Inspectorate of Government Act, Cap. 32, to monitor and curb unethical behaviour, while the Access to Information Act, Cap. 95, has supported greater transparency around public information more broadly.

These reforms have produced genuine achievements: improved service delivery in areas such as health and education, increased efficiency through streamlined government processes, enhanced accountability and transparency, and strengthened institutional capacity. Real challenges remain, however: resistance to change among some public servants, continuing capacity constraints including skills gaps, persistent corruption undermining reform effectiveness despite institutional safeguards, and concerns about the long term sustainability of reforms given continued reliance on donor funding and political will.

Looking ahead, achieving the goals of Uganda's Vision 2040 national development plan will depend on continued investment in digital solutions, ongoing training, stronger monitoring mechanisms, and simplifying HR regulations, alongside fostering a genuinely honest culture within the civil service.

> ***Reflect:*** *Given the achievements and challenges covered in this lesson, do you think Uganda's public sector HR reforms since 1986 have, on balance, succeeded or fallen short of their original goals? What evidence would you point to either way?*

Bringing Strategic HRM and Public Sector Reform Together

This module connected two levels of Strategic HRM. Lesson 1 covered how any organisation aligns its HR practices with its overall strategy. Lesson 2 applied that same thinking to Uganda's public sector specifically, showing decades of deliberate reform aimed at making government HR more merit based, accountable, and effective.

A useful closing thought: the public sector faces the exact same SHRM challenges covered in Lesson 1, aligning practice with strategy, managing change, measuring effectiveness, and balancing short and long term goals, just at a much larger and more politically complex scale. Understanding both levels together gives a fuller picture of how HR actually shapes outcomes, whether in a single private company or across an entire country's civil service.

The next module moves from strategy and government reform into the detailed mechanics of job analysis, job design, and job evaluation, the practical tools that turn any organisation's strategy into specific, well defined roles.